

A Chronology of the Art of Ding Ha

1923

Ding Ha was born in Shanghai on August 17th 1923 (July 6th 1923, in the Chinese lunar calendar). His original name was Bixing Ha, however, he changed his name after starting his long, arduous but successful journey into the world of art.

Ha's grandfather Shaofu Ha, who lived from 1856 to 1934, came from Nanjing and was the son of a great businessman in Shanghai. Shaofu Ha was also an important figure of the Hui ethnic group and famous for his huge collection of calligraphy, drawings, paintings and antiques in Shanghai. After Changshuo Wu, the first director of Xiling Seal Art Society, passed away in 1927, Shaofu Ha was elected to be the second director of the Xiling Seal Art Society.



1930-1936

7-13 years old

When Ding Ha was seven he attended the Shang Xian Tang Elementary School, later transferring to the Dun Hua Elementary School that was founded by his grandfather, and learned Chinese painting from his father.

1936-1942

13-19 years old

Ha initially attended the Province-founded Shanghai Middle School, but later he transferred to Da Cheng Middle School.

In 1942 19 years old

Ha was admitted to Dong Wu University (Shanghai Campus), but later dropped out due to financial difficulty.

1942-1947 19-24 years old

Ha attended the Chong Ren Studio and studied oil painting from Chongren Zhang, subsequently becoming his assistant teacher.



1943 20 years old

Ha's watercolor painting was awarded a grade A prize in the first art exhibition by the YMCA of Shanghai.

1946 23 years old

Ha was hired as an instructor at the Art Studio of Jiaotong National University.

1947 24 years old

Ha's oil painting *Spring* was entered in the annual competition of the Zhong Zheng Culture of Art.

The art history of Ding Ha was included in the Biography of Artists (1947) in the *Yearbook of Shanghai Art*.

Additionally, many of his sketches and watercolor paintings were recorded in the painting catalog of the *Yearbook of Shanghai Art*.

1948 25 years old

Ha was recruited as an art teacher at Aurora Girl's Middle School (now Xiang Ming Middle School) in 1948.

1948-1949 25-26 years old

Due to financial difficulty, Ha often drew portraits for American soldiers at dance clubs and cafes. In the meantime, he became a famous young portraitist in Shanghai for his custom-made portrait business listed at Yong An Company at Nanjing Road and Da Xing Company.

1949 26 years old

After Shanghai was liberated in May, the orders for landscapes and portraits decreased and, for a while, he painted the portraits of national leaders.



1950 27 years old

Ha opened an art studio for the first time, with the first students including Jieyin Wang, Ka Pang and Lianbao Dong (amongst others).

1952 29 years old

According to a regulation established by the State Council, school departments at this time needed to be reorganized. Both the Shanghai School of Fine Arts and the Suzhou School of Fine Arts, Shanghai Campus, were relocated, leaving Shanghai with no

professional art schools. With the encouragement of the Culture Administration, Ha planned to open a formal art studio to nurture the sorely needed art talents.

1953 30 years old

On May 12th 1953, Ha married Wenqi Zhang and received a registration of marriage at the Municipal Government in Xincheng District, Shanghai.

On June 10th, he received a license from the Cultural Businesses Administration and the art studio of Ding Ha was officially founded at 153 Xuqing Road, Xuhui District. In the same year, the book named *Learning Materials for Watercolor Painting*, which was co-authored by Ding Ha and Yongsen Li, was published by the People's Fine Arts Press.

1954 31 years old

How to: Portrait was published by the Shanghai Cultural Publication Press.

Ha accompanied 10-plus students to Haitong Aluminum Factory, where Lianbao Dong worked, to both paint and allow students to experience the conditions of local life. During this time, *The Boiler Firemen*, an artistic composition work of charcoal pencil and light color was created.

1955-1956 32-33 years old

Ha also took 10-plus students to a rural cooperatives and steel roll factory in Zhudi Town, to again accomplish some natural painting expertise but at the same time 'be confronted and aware of the local life experienced daily by others'.



How to: Portrait Painting was overwhelmingly popular so its new edition was republished in December 1956. In the following 18 months, it was reprinted 6 more times with a total number of 159,000 copies.

1957 34 years old

Ha became a member of the China Artists' Association (Shanghai Branch)

The Communist Party released a directive named "To Bring Culture and Art to Rural Areas". In response, Ding Ha traveled to the rural areas to gain some on-site life experience and achieved tremendous results. Six (6) pictures from the Ding Ha Studio were selected and entered in the *National Exhibition of Young Artists* and this ensured Ha's studio was the preeminent provider in Shanghai.

How to: Pencil Drawing was published by the Shanghai Cultural Publication Press in June 1957, with the book being reprinted 4 more times in the following year for a total number of 125,000 copies.

The oil painting *The Train of Children* was published by the monthly magazine *The Bud*, and the watercolor painting *Herding Ducks* was selected to *The Art Exhibition of the World Youth*. This was held in the former USSR (Soviet Union) and this artistic news was later published by *The People's Daily*.



1958 35 years old

The main watercolor paintings during this time were *By the Huangpu River* and *Research*, etc.

1959 36 years old

The oil painting *Research* was published by Shanghai People's Press

August 1960 - July 1963

37 to 40 years old

Ha was hired as a lecturer of fundamental courses at the Shanghai School of Fine Arts. He taught watercolor painting for preparatory students, sketching for college students, and art creation for secondary school students. During this time period, he often took students to visit rural areas, factories, etc, and accomplished significant results through his impressive on-site creative teaching ability and methods.



1960 37 years old

The watercolor paintings, *Morning at the Huangpu River* and *By the Huangpu River*, were displayed at the *National Exhibition of Watercolor*

Painting. Also, the watercolor painting *The Bridge by Chenghuang Temple* was collected by the National Art Museum of China.

1961 38 years old

The main watercolor paintings: *The Bund in the Rain* and *The City in Summer*

1962 39 years old

Ha attended a forum on watercolor painting in Beijing and discussed the development of watercolor painting in China with 17 other watercolor artists such as Meisun Zhang, Yongsen Li, Fengmian Lin, Sitong Pan, Jianchen Li, Chongren Zhang, Shufang Xiao, Mingti Fan and Guanzhong Wu, etc.

1963 40 years old

Ha joined the China Artists' Associations at the recommendation of the Shanghai Artists' Association.

The oil painting *Ruijin Bridge* and 7 other paintings were selected for the *Shanghai Oil Painting Exhibition* to be held in Hong Kong.

Shanghai School of Fine Arts stopped recruiting new students and started to reduce the number of teachers. Due to his established reputation, Ha was asked to leave the school and reopen his studio with the purpose of sharing the "burden of the country"

The watercolor painting "*The Hearts of Workers*" was published by *Jiefang Daily*.



1964 41 years old

His book *The Skills of Watercolor Painting* was published by the Shanghai People's Art Press (the book was published for the first time with a total number of 35,000 copies). This book includes Ha's article *How to: Draw Streets Scenery* and his watercolor painting *The City in Summer*.

1966-1976 43-53 years old

Ha was labeled as a typical case of "capitalist" in the art circle of Shanghai during the Cultural Revolution. After the crazy destruction performed by the "Red Guard", Ha's studio was closed and he was brutally criticized and tortured by the "rebels". With zero financial support from his studio, Ha was compelled to make his living the hard way by accomplishing laborious tasks at Shanghai No.1 Wheel Factory, Qibao Wine Factory, Shanghai Tobacco factory and the Yimin Food Factory.

October 1976 53 years old

The Cultural Revolution finally ended and Ha immediately created the oil painting *Chrysanthemum*, which exhibited a unique brightness of color and unrestrained brushwork. It obviously represented the delight and happiness that Ha experienced at the time, plus his ambitions for the future.

In 1978, when he was 55 years old, Ha worked as a full time painter at the Shanghai Painting and Calligraphy Academy.

1978 55 years old

Ha was hired as a professional painter at Shanghai Academy of Painting in July.

1979 56 years old

In this year, Ha spent a month at the fishing port in Shenjiamen. His watercolor painting *Aspirations* was selected for the Exhibition of Portraits Paintings collected from six provinces and one directly administered city in 1979.



1980 57 years old

Ha spent 50 days at the construction site at the Gezhou Dam and, subsequently, the watercolor paintings *Gezhou Dam In Rain* and *The Construction Site of Gezhou Dam* were published in the 10th volume of *The Art* magazine that same year. Also, the watercolor painting *The Fishing Port in Shenjiamen* was selected for the Exhibition of Portraits Paintings collected from six provinces and one directly administered city in 1980.

1981 58 years old

Ha spent a month painting from nature in Guangxi Province.

In the same year, the watercolor painting *The Construction Site of Gezhou Dam* was published by the Takung Newspaper.



1982 59 years old

Ha spent a month painting from nature on the prairies in Inner Mongolia.



His writing *How to: Watercolor Painting* was published on *China Youth Daily*.

The Picture Album of Ding Ha's Watercolor Painting was published by *Ethnic Solidarity*.

Ding Ha's Watercolor Paintings was published in the 4th volume of *Guangxi Pictorial Magazine*.

The watercolor painting *Grass, Flowers and Vase* was published by the Shanghai People's Art Press.

1983 60 years old

Invited by the Literary Federation and Artists' Association in Tibet Autonomous Region, Ha visited Tibet to absorb himself in 'painting from nature'. Furthermore, he held numerous impromptu art training classes in order to teach the local talent.



On January 1st 1983, the *Wen Hui Daily* published a 'highly regarded, plus an undersigned comment' on his watercolor painting *New Year for New Stories*, which was created in 1963

On July 5th, the *Beijing Review* published three of his sketches from Inner Mongolia.

On September 5th, the *Inner Mongolian Workers* published *Talking about My Watercolor Painting "Busy Morning"* and a picture was published on the back cover.

The 9th volume of *People's Pictorial* published an article named *Ding Ha's Watercolor Painting*, plus his watercolor paintings "*Waves*" and "*Rosa Chinensis*".

On September 17th the *Xizang Daily* published some photos depicting Ha and his students, from the Zang nationality, attending open-air training classes painting from nature with an inscription beneath the photos stating: "Ding Ha, who is a painter from Shanghai Painting and Calligraphy Academy, during his time in Tibet".

In November, Jieren Xu wrote an article, "*The Paintings that Ding Ha Produced in the Past 5 Years, An Authentically Artistic Presentation of Our Motherland*", and the article was published in the *Wen Hui Daily*. Two other sketches, "*Zang Opera*" and "*The Biggest Temple in Tibet - the Zhebeng Temple*", were also published.

Wen Hui Daily published Ha's sketch "*Jokhang Temple*" on November 6th.

His watercolor painting "*The Golden Pond*" was published on *China Report*.

1984 61 years old

The watercolor painting "*Sceneries of Border Areas*" was selected for the 6th National Exhibition of Art.

The Collection of Ding Ha's Watercolor Paintings was published by Beijing Foreign Language Press, and also in the *Jiangsu Pictorial Magazine*, as specials.

"*Sceneries of Border Areas*" and "*The Roof of the World*" were collected by The National Art Museum of China.

"*The Sceneries of Prairies*" was collected by Shanghai Art Museum.

1985 62 years old

On June 1st, 1985, Jieren Xu posted a news report, "I Am Eager to Get Close to Life - Great Achievement was made by Ding Ha in Rural and Border Areas", in the *Wen Hui Daily*.

The book *Watercolor Painting Skills* was published by China Artists Association, Shanghai Branch. The bi-monthly magazine, *The Breeze in Spring*, published *The Collection of Ding Ha's Watercolor Paintings*.

The Picture Album of Ding Ha was published by the People's Fine Art Press. The preface was written by Peng Shen, vice president of China Federation of Literary and Art Circles.

1986 63 years old

Ha joined a 4-member invited Chinese art delegation and visited the Indian Ocean Islands of Madagascar, Seychelles, Mauritius and La Reunion at the beginning of the year, where his skill and talent as an artist was displayed in painting and calligraphy exhibitions and more of his impromptu, friendly instructional art classes. There were 40 paintings from Ding Ha.

On January 25th, the local Chinese Press in Mauritius published the article *"Two Famous Chinese Painters Will Visit Us Tomorrow and the Exhibition Will be Opened on Next Wednesday"*, in reference to Ding Ha and ChenSheng Dong.

On January 30th, the local Chinese Press further reported the news that the Minister of Education attended the opening ceremony of the exhibition of dozens of Chinese paintings made by two outstanding Chinese painters, who had arrived at Mauritius and received great comments.

All newspapers at these locations published articles and photos about the events and the pictures presented by Ding Ha and Chensheng Dong, introducing them and their exhibition.



On May 8th, the *People's Daily* published Ha's two sketches made in Seychelles, and the Ile De La Reunion area, entitled *"The Sketches Made in Africa"*.

On May 29th, the *Wei Hui Daily* published two of his sketches.

From July to October, Ding Ha spent three months painting in Dunhuang, Gansu and Xinjiang, with other painters from the Shanghai Oil Painting and Sculpture Academy.

On Oct 22nd, the *Kashgar Daily* published an article named *The Famous Painter of Hui Nationality Spent Months in Our Region*.

The watercolor painting *The Market in Madagascar* was selected for the National Exhibition of Poster Paintings and Watercolor Paintings.

The Picture Album of Ding Ha was published by the People's Fine Arts Press.

The watercolor painting *The Flowers on the Plateau of Pamirs* was collected by the Shanghai Art Museum.

1987 64 years old

In March, the *Wen Hui Monthly* published an article named *Ha's Days in Africa* with two of his watercolors painted in Africa. On May 22nd, the column *The Writers* in *Wen Hui Daily* published an article, written by Ding Ha, named "*Perusing the Good Things in Life*". In June, *Ta Kung Daily* in HK published a special coverage named *Yemin Zhong Ding Ha's Friendship Brought By Paintings in HK* by Zhongmin Ye. On June 19th, the *New Evening Post* (HK) published an article named *From Teaching to Painting, His Art Experience in His Own Words* written by Hanru Jiang. In August, the *Mingpao Monthly* (Volume. 260) published Ha's article *My Watercolor Paintings* with another 14 paintings. The *Artist* (HK) published an article named *Appreciating Ding Ha's Watercolor Paintings* written by Zhenzhi He, a commentator in art, as well as another 14 paintings. The oil painting entitled *The Roof of the World* was published by *China Daily*.

Two oil paintings, *The Fall* and *The Roof of the World*, were selected for the The Exhibition of Chinese Contemporary Oil Painting, which was organized by China Artists Association and GHK from April 1st to 20th in NYC.

The watercolor paintings, *The Waves* and *The Buddhism Horn*, were selected for The International Exhibition on Watercolor Paintings 1987, at The Mall Gallery, which was organized by The Royal Watercolor Society in London.

1988 65 years old

The watercolor paintings, *Palio* and *Scenery in Border Areas*, were selected for The International Exhibition on Watercolor Paintings 1988, at The Mall Gallery, which was organized by The Royal Watercolor Society in London.

The watercolor painting *The Market in Madagascar* was selected for The Exhibition of Chinese Watercolor Painting, which was organized by a Chinese foreign exhibition company. The exhibition was held in Kuwait and North Korea.

Jointly organized by Shanghai Oil Painting and Sculpture Academy, Shanghai Cultural Development Foundation, Shanghai Municipal Administration of Cultural Affairs and the Shanghai Art Museum, Ding Ha's Individual Exhibition was held at Shanghai Art Museum from September 30th to October 8th. There were 140 items presented including his sketches, watercolor paintings and oil paintings. On October 1st, the *Jiefang Daily*, *Wen Hui Daily*, *Xinming Evening Post* and other newspapers with a high circulation all reported the news of this exhibition. *Morning Flower*, a column on *Jiefang Daily* published the article, *Ding Ha's Watercolor Paintings*, with one of his watercolor paintings, *The Daughter of Pamir*. Lijian, a reporter of the *Xinming Evening Post*, wrote an article named *Pursuing Colors for 50 Years: An Interview with Ding Ha*, and placed his watercolor painting *The Central Mall* next to the article.

On Oct 12th, Zhenzhi He wrote an article in the *Wen Hui Daily* named *The 40 Years of Ding Ha's Painting*.

On Oct 23rd, Keren Xu wrote an article in the *Xinmin Evening Post* named *Painting on the Roof of the World*, and published both his painting *Temple* and a photo taken when Ha was instructing the students.

On Oct 26th Ha's watercolor painting *The Town of Luzhi* was published in the special column of *Bihui*.

The critique *The Golden Pond*, which is co-authored by Weiyu Wu and Shan Su, was published on *Tourism (Shanghai)*.

Elementary Watercolor Painting Skills was published by the Shanghai People's Art Press.

1989 66 years old

Ding Ha's watercolor painting, *The Flowers on Pamirs*, was selected for The 7th National Exhibition of Art.

On Oct 22nd, Jihan Liu wrote an article named *Wealth Thrives the Home and Moral Thrives the Body, an Interview with the Famous Watercolor Painter Ding Ha* on *Luoyang Daily*. He indicated that "Very few well-achieved mature artists did not benefit from *How to: Portrait Painting* and *How to: Pencil Drawing*, the two books written by Ding Ha". These two books were published in the 1950s and were the bestsellers at that time. Ding Ha used to be someone whose name was well known by everyone in the art area."

In the same year, with their daughter's arrangement, Mr. and Mrs. Ha settled down in the United States of America.

1990 67 years old

Guanyun Ou wrote in the *Xinmin Evening Post* about Zhenya Xia's words on watercolor painting. Xia said "Ha's watercolor portrait paintings contain extensive details, and such dense colors that they are similar to oil paintings".

1991 68 years old

Watercolor painting *Lama Musician*, *Palio (one and two)*, *Hard-working Tibetan Girls* and *Chinese Roses*.

1992 69 years old

From July 23rd to August 13th, Ding Ha had his individual watercolor painting exhibition in the Moros Studio Gallery, Santa Monica, Los Angeles, CA.



On July 11th the *World Daily* (CA) headlined the news *Exhibition of Ding Ha's Oil Paintings, for 3 Weeks from 23rd* and posted a photo in which Ding Ha was standing in front of his paintings. On the same day, the *International Daily* also headlined an article named *Ding Ha's works, a Tour of all Nationalities in China*. The Sing Tao Daily reported an article *Ding Ha's Paintings Made in the Past 50 Years in Border Areas, the Passion Shown on Every Piece*.

1993 70 years old

The watercolor painting *Palio* (I and II), *Hard-working Tibetan Girls* and *The Dialogue* were selected for The Exhibition of Watercolor Painting 1993, at the Mall Gallery, which was organized by the Royal Watercolor Society in London.

The series of *Palio* was published by RA Magazine

On its 30th Anniversary, the National Art Museum of China held an exhibition of selected collections, and Ha's *Sceneries of Border Areas* was selected for the display.

1994 71 years old

Palio III, The Sunshine in the Early Morning

1995 72 years old

The Sunshine in the Early Morning was selected for the exhibition, *The Hometown - the Paintings made by 100 Overseas Chinese*, which was jointly organized by the Shanghai Pudong Administration of Social Development and Shanghai Artists Association.

1996 73 years old

The exhibition *Watermarks* was held in California and Ding Ha's paintings, such as *Shared Happiness with Pigeons*, *A Tibetan Old Man*, *Band in Classics*, *The Dialogue* and *A Senior Herd*, were displayed at the event.

Four pieces of Ha's watercolor paintings have been recorded by Complete Works of Chinese Modern Fine Arts (Watercolor): *The Streamside in Summer*, *Sceneries of Border Areas*, *The Bright Sunshine* and *Palio II*.

Ding Ha's work, *The Rising up of Shanghai*, was awarded a significant prize in the exhibition of watercolor painting *I Love Shanghai*, which was jointly organized by The Information Office of the Shanghai City Hall and the Shanghai Artists Association. Later, this watercolor painting was collected by the Municipal Government of Shanghai.



This glorious event was widely reported by newspapers such as the *Wen Hui Daily* and the *Xinmin Evening Post* on February 13th. Jing Li from the *Xinmin Evening Post* conducted an exclusive interview with Ding Ha.

From February 17th to 23rd, Ding Ha's *Palio* was displayed at The 4th Watercolor Exhibition of Shanghai Art, which was jointly organized by the Shanghai Watercolor Painting Research Association and the Shanghai Art Museum.

On March 26th, Jinde Lu, of the *Xinmin Evening Post*, commented positively regarding Ha's newly finished work *Palio* in his article *Ding Ha's Watercolor Painting*.

1999 76 years old

Ha's work, *The Rising up of Shanghai*, joined The Exhibition of Shanghai Watercolor Painting held in Chicago, Los Angeles and other locations.

2000 77 years old

The Collection of Ding Ha's Painting was published by Shanghai People's Press and the preface was written by Charles Bone, a former President of the Royal Institute of Painters in Watercolor in the UK.

2002 79 years old

The premiere of *The Collection of Ding Ha's Painting* was held in New Jersey.

Since the middle of the 1980s, especially after he was settled in the US, Ding Ha accomplished art creation whilst studying Buddhism with all his heart. His works' focus had gradually moved inexorably onwards to an expression of purity in nature, the truth, the kindness, and the beauty of life.



2003

Ding Ha passed away on July 3rd in a hospital in Los Angeles at the age of 80.

On July 12th, his funeral was held at Rose Hills Mortuary Sky Rose Chapel in the Los Angeles area. The representative from the Consulate of P.R.C. in Los Angeles attended and addressed the funeral.